Reproduction II

ANIMALS AND PLANTS EMPLOY A RANGE OF STRATEGIES TO REPRODUCE.

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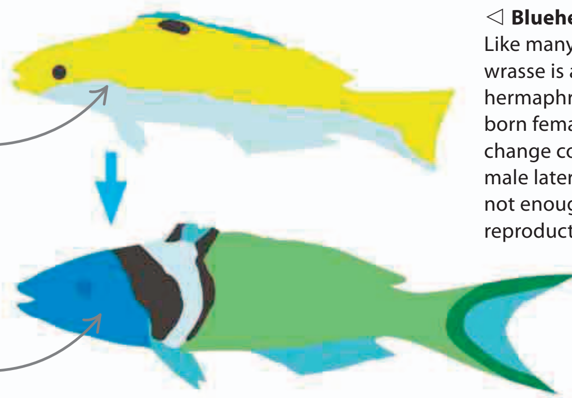
Plants and animals employ a number of reproduction strategies to maximize their breeding potential. This may involve changing from one sex to another, or relying on other animals to aid in reproduction and dispersal of offspring.

Hermaphrodites

Sex cells are produced by organs known as gonads. The female gonad is the ovary; the male one is the testis. Animals that have both types of gonads at some point in their lives are known as hermaphrodites. Earthworms and land snails are simultaneous hermaphrodites, meaning they have both gonads at the same time. Nevertheless, they still need to find mates to breed.



◁ **Bluehead wrasse**
Like many fish, the bluehead wrasse is a sequential hermaphrodite—most are born female, but they can change color and become male later if there are not enough males for reproduction to take place.

Marsupials

Most female mammals sustain a developing fetus inside the uterus or womb using a placenta. The placenta transfers oxygen and nutrients into the fetus's blood supply. The baby is born once it has developed enough to survive independently. The young of marsupials are born at an earlier stage of development than those of other mammals. Instead of being fed from a placenta in the uterus, they continue their growth in their mother's pouch, or marsupium.

▷ **Kangaroo**
Baby kangaroos, or joeys, are born after just 31 days of development inside the mother. They then make a dangerous journey from the birth canal, over the mother's fur to the safety of the mother's pouch.

Joeys are only about 2 cm (0.8 in) long when they are born and weigh less than 1 g (0.4 oz).